Washington Safeguarding Baseline 2026

What randomly sampled nonprofits publicly disclose about protecting the people they serve

The U.S. Nonprofit Safeguarding Crosswalk Project · First edition · September 2026

This study evaluates public-facing safeguarding and child-protection governance disclosures across Washington nonprofit organizations. It asks a question any parent, participant, volunteer, or referring agency might ask: when you look an organization up, what does its own website tell you about how it protects the people in its care? The sample is a stratified random draw of 120 organizations from IRS nonprofit records — not a hand-picked list — so the answer is a baseline for the sector, not a portrait of a few chosen organizations.

About this study. All 120 sampled organizations are fully coded: the author personally reviewed every organization's website evidence, resolved every unclear item by reading the sites directly, and read all 120 Form 990 filings. Results are reported for the 100 sampled organizations that serve program participants directly (see The sample). No organization is identified anywhere in this release.

The regulatory gap this study measures

Module 1 of the Crosswalk Project established that the United States lacks a legal requirement of general application that both reaches the nonprofit sector as a class and protects the people nonprofits serve. Because internal operations are invisible to the public, this study specifically measures public-facing infrastructure—asking what share of organizations explicitly disclose their safeguarding policies and reporting channels on their websites.

Public evidence is not internal practice, in either direction: an organization may run systems it never mentions online, and a published policy may be shelfware. "No" means *not publicly found under the protocol*, never "the organization has nothing."

The sample

The study population: Washington-registered 501(c)(3) charities in the IRS categories for human services and youth development with annual revenue of at least $250,000 — **882 organizations**. From these, a stratified random sample of **120** was drawn (60 youth-serving, 60 serving adults or vulnerable adults) with a documented, reproducible seed. On inspection, 20 of the 120 turned out not to deliver services directly to individuals — foundations that raise or grant money, associations whose members are other organizations, and event organizers. These 20 were screened out as out of scope: an entity with no program participants cannot be expected to publish participant-protection signals, and keeping such entities in the denominator would distort what the study measures. Screening a random draw for eligibility — and reporting the screening — is standard survey practice, and the table below accounts for every organization drawn. **All results below describe the 100 in-scope organizations that serve program participants directly.**

	Youth-serving	Adult / vulnerable-adult	Total
Randomly drawn	60	60	120
Out of scope (no direct services to individuals)	10	10	20
Analyzed in this report	**50**	**50**	**100**

Scope reflects an organization's role, not its website content: a few out-of-scope entities do publish safety-related material (an event organizer's sport-safety rules, for example). Their rows are excluded from numerator and denominator alike — codes recorded for out-of-scope entities during screening never enter the statistics — so every figure in this report describes the same 100 organizations.

The six indicators

Each organization's own website was coded Yes, No, or Unclear against a written codebook, with an evidence URL and verbatim quote required for every Yes:

Indicator	Coded Yes when the organization's own website shows…
W1 Published policy	a safeguarding, child-protection, or participant-protection policy with substantive rules protecting the people served
W2 Conduct code	an identifiable code of conduct governing behaviour toward the people served — a named code document or an explicit statement that personnel sign one; safety-rule language elsewhere on a site does not by itself qualify
W3 Participant reporting channel	a visible way for participants, families, or the public to raise a safety or conduct concern
W4 Volunteer screening	an explicit statement that volunteers — not only staff — undergo background checks
W5 Safeguarding training	safeguarding, abuse-prevention, or mandated-reporter training for staff or volunteers
W6 Named role	a named person or role designated to oversee safeguarding or child safety

Why a random sample matters

The 120 organizations were selected blind, by an algorithm with a documented seed — the author did not choose them, and none could be added or removed by hand. Because this was a blind, random draw, the results provide an

unbiased baseline. The high rates of public silence are not an anomaly isolated to a few poorly governed organizations; rather, they demonstrate a widespread, sector-level gap.

High-level findings

34%
show at least one public safeguarding signal

66%
show zero public safeguarding signals

Of the 100 direct-service organizations, **34% show at least one safeguarding signal** — most often a stated background-check requirement for volunteers. The other **66% show zero public safeguarding signals**: they scored "No" on all six indicators measured below.

Performance across the six indicators

% Yes	Indicator	What a "Yes" means here
11%	Published policy (W1)	They publish a safeguarding, child-protection, or participant-protection policy.
4%	Code of conduct (W2)	They publish a named code of conduct, or state that personnel sign one.
11%	Reporting channel (W3)	They show a way to raise a safety or conduct concern.
24%	Volunteer screening (W4)	They explicitly state that background checks are required for volunteers.
11%	Safeguarding training (W5)	They state that staff or volunteers receive safeguarding, abuse-prevention, or mandated-reporter training.
7%	Named role (W6)	They name a person or role who oversees safeguarding or child safety.

Counts of 100: Yes / No per line — W1 11/89 · W2 4/96 · W3 11/89 · W4 24/76 · W5 11/89 · W6 7/93.

Depth of signal

Indicators coded Yes	Organizations

5 or 6 (a full published system)	4
3 or 4	5
1 or 2	25
0	66

All four organizations with a full published system are local affiliates of a single national youth-serving network whose parent body imposes safeguarding standards on its affiliates.

National networks versus independent organizations

	n	At least one signal	Mean indicators coded Yes
Local affiliates of a national or federated body	17	12 (71%)	2.2
Independent organizations	83	22 (27%)	0.4

Being part of a national network is the strongest predictor of a public safeguarding signal in this sample: 71% of local affiliates show at least one, against 27% of independent organizations. But the effect is not automatic — local chapters are highly inconsistent. Within a single network, one local unit surfaced its parent's protection program on its own site while another published almost none of it, and affiliates of networks with well-known safeguarding standards sometimes published nothing locally at all. **An umbrella body's policy is not the local organization's public signal until the local organization explicitly displays or links to it on their own public-facing site.**

Youth-serving versus adult-serving organizations

Stratum	n	At least one signal	W1	W2	W3	W4	W5	W6
Youth-serving	50	19 (38%)	10	1	9	14	10	6
Adult / vulnerable-adult	50	15 (30%)	1	3	2	10	1	1

The gap between the strata mirrors U.S. law itself, in which what protection exists clusters around minors — most sharply on published policies and training. The conduct-code line is the one exception: under the strict named-code bar, most youth-sector conduct rules live inside broader safety pages rather than as an identifiable code, and only one youth-serving organization publishes one.

A Bright Spot in the Data

One of the strongest independent safeguarding frameworks in the sample — a published code of ethics, a mandatory-reporting policy, and annual state-police screening of every volunteer — belonged to an organization serving older adults, with no national parent and no licensing mandate requiring any of it. If an organization with no network or mandate behind it can build and publish a framework like this, publication does not depend on either.

Silence is the norm; it is not solely a matter of capacity.

Duty versus visibility

Several sampled organizations operate in licensed sub-sectors that already carry safeguarding-type duties — certified long-term care under 42 C.F.R. Part 483, state-licensed disability services, licensed childcare and child-placing agencies. Their public signal varied widely, even within one sector: one licensed disability provider publishes a full participant handbook with a multi-step grievance procedure; another in the same sector publishes nothing; a large licensed continuing-care community subject to federal resident-rights and grievance rules shows no public signal at all. Regulation reliably creates the obligation. Whether a family searching online can see it still depends on the organization.

A methodological note: the personnel-status gap in public signals

Safeguarding protects participants from *all* personnel — employees and volunteers alike — and the coding here is deliberately personnel-neutral: a policy, conduct code, or training reference counts whichever class it names, and only the volunteer-screening indicator (W4) is class-specific by design. Readers of the underlying evidence will nonetheless notice a pattern: the published instruments most often name *volunteers*. That skew has a structural explanation, and it matters for interpretation.

Volunteer-facing materials are published because volunteers are recruited from the public: a background-check requirement, a code volunteers sign, or a pre-service training expectation must appear on the recruitment page or applicants would never encounter it. Staff-facing compliance, by contrast, typically lives where the public cannot see it — in internal HR handbooks, onboarding systems, employment contracts — and is separately driven by employment law, insurer requirements, and, in licensed sub-sectors, by regulators. A volunteer-heavy public signal therefore does not mean staff are unprotected; it means the web shows the half of the system aimed at outsiders.

The interpretive consequence cuts the other way as well. Module 1 of this project found that United States law allocates protective and procedural duties by *employment status* rather than by function — the "personnel-status gap" — leaving volunteers largely outside the legal instruments that discipline staff conduct. The public record examined here is consistent with that structure: screening statements about staff appear mainly as licensing boilerplate on employment pages (and are recorded in the study's notes when found), while the organizations that

visibly bind *both* classes in one published framework — naming employees, volunteers, and board members together — are a small minority, concentrated among affiliates whose national bodies require exactly that. Whether an organization's published safeguarding framework reaches everyone who faces participants, or only the personnel class the law happens to regulate, is the question a domestic baseline standard would settle; the full personnel-coverage analysis will accompany the final report.

The comparator

The study's design pairs the website indicators with two Form 990 governance items every filing nonprofit answers — whether it has a written whistleblower policy (Part VI, line 13) and a conflict-of-interest policy (line 12a). Author reading of the filed returns is complete for the full sample: across all 120 most recent filings read, **100% report a written whistleblower policy and 100% report a conflict-of-interest policy** — while 11% of the 100 direct-service organizations publish a safeguarding policy and 11% give participants a visible way to raise a concern. The two figures measure different things: what organizations reported to the IRS, and what they publish. Where a form asks, a filed answer exists for every organization; no form asks about safeguarding, so how many hold a safeguarding policy internally is unknown.

Method and verification

Website indicators were coded in stages. A first pass was performed by an AI coding assistant applying the written codebook under a fixed per-organization search protocol, with an evidence URL and verbatim quote required for every positive code and "unclear" — never "absent" — recorded wherever a page could not be rendered. Every positive code was then re-verified against the cited page in a second, independent pass, and every row was reviewed by the author, who read the sites automated tools could not render, resolved every remaining unclear item directly, and made the final decision on every cell. Fifteen organizations were additionally double-coded blind by the author and the first-pass process: initial cell-level agreement was 54% (49 of 90 cells). The disagreements were systematic rather than random — safety pages located under "About" submenus that a quick pass misses, and evidence drawn from a national parent's site rather than the sampled organization's own — and all were resolved against the cited evidence, producing two codebook rules now applied throughout. Borderline cells were adjudicated by the author against a single bar per indicator; for the conduct-code indicator that bar is strict (an identifiable, named code or signed-code statement), which is why several organizations with substantial published safety rules are nonetheless coded No on that one line. All figures in this report are direct tallies of the 100 in-scope organizations' coded rows — because the analyzed group is exactly 100, every percentage is also the raw count. The full audit log (every change, with evidence and date) is retained.

Limitations

- Public evidence versus practice, in both directions (see above).

- The Form 990 comparator rests on the author's complete manual reading of all 120 sampled filings, each recorded against its filing link in the study workbook. Any manual reading of hundreds of tax documents carries a standard, inherent risk of isolated transcription error; any such isolated error would be structurally immaterial to the sector-level gap documented in this report. These are also self-reported checkbox answers, which attest to a policy's existence, not its use.
- The revenue floor excludes the smallest organizations — where capacity is thinnest.
- About 21% of Washington public charities carry no activity code in the IRS file and could not enter the study population.
- IRS registration data are imperfect: some sampled entities had changed names, merged, or let domains lapse; identities were confirmed against filings before coding.
- Coding reflects a single date (August–September 2026); websites change.
- Washington is one state. The design is portable and replication is invited under CC BY 4.0.

Ethics statement

Results are reported in aggregate only. No sampled organization is identified, and none will be named for the absence of an indicator. Positive exemplars will be named only with written permission. Every sampled organization will receive this report and the project's free, open-licensed safeguarding toolkit.

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